Hundreds of senior economists and figures from the academic world, joined by thousands of students, have sent warning letters or joined the protests. All of this, according to Netanyahu, is but “a tsunami of lies.” A previous head of the Shin Bet (the Israeli equivalent of the FBI) calls for a general strike to paralyze the country. Maybe nothing else will help.

Thursday, January 26

The major question regarding the post-1967 craziness and the standing occupation of the Palestinian territories is whether a messianic impulse is embedded in Zionism as such, or whether it mainly characterizes a segment, particularly a religious segment, of the population.

Zionism, during the period stretching from Theodor Herzl in the late nineteenth century to Begin’s electoral victory in 1977, was essentially a secular movement, starting as such with Herzl himself, Zabotinsky, Chaim Weizmann, Ben-Gurion, and the major political parties (some of them originally Marxist) that dominated the political landscape. Until the Six-Day War the religious parties that actively participated in successive governments were moderate and accommodating (Yosef Burg’s Mafdal, for example). But after that victory, they split and one wing became “messianic,” seeing in the conquest of the whole of Eretz Israel the onset of redemption. As for Agudath Israel, it had no noticeable influence on political decisions and cared about its own interests only. As previously mentioned, private life in Israel was governed by religious rules, if and when a person needed to resort to them, but otherwise the religious presence was disregarded by an important part of the population. Now the newfangled demands of the religious parties have become one of the main dynamics in the internal conflict, and they may have a political majority supporting them in the Knesset.